

# Strong Willed Child Guide — Action Checklist

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## REFRAME YOUR GOAL

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- ☐ **Stop trying to win power struggles and instead focus on training your child's self-regulation, because the daily battle itself is teaching your child that resistance is the appropriate response to authority.:** Stop trying to win power struggles and instead focus on training your child's self-regulation, because the daily battle itself is teaching your child that resistance is the appropriate response to authority.
- ☐ **Ask yourself whether your child is exercising a will or demonstrating that they lack the will-muscle to control themselves, because what looks like defiance is actually a child who cannot yet stop themselves.:** Ask yourself whether your child is exercising a will or demonstrating that they lack the will-muscle to control themselves, because what looks like defiance is actually a child who cannot yet stop themselves.
- ☐ **Replace the goal of breaking your child's will with the goal of training it, because Mason's analysis shows that what appears as 'too much will' is actually too little impulse control.:** Replace the goal of breaking your child's will with the goal of training it, because Mason's analysis shows that what appears as 'too much will' is actually too little impulse control.
- ☐ **See yourself as your child's trainer rather than their adversary, because the power struggle model assumes someone must win and someone must lose, which is the wrong framework entirely.:** See yourself as your child's trainer rather than their adversary, because the power struggle model assumes someone must win and someone must lose, which is the wrong framework entirely.

## SHAPE YOUR HOME ENVIRONMENT

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- ☐ **Notice the emotional temperature of your home each day and ask whether it feels calm and warm, because children absorb the atmosphere unconsciously and it shapes their nervous system.:** Notice the emotional temperature of your home each day and ask whether it feels calm and warm, because children absorb the atmosphere unconsciously and it shapes their nervous system.
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- **Lower the background noise level and reduce raised voices among adults in your household, because a consistently calm environment provides invisible education that a tense, chaotic home cannot.:** Lower the background noise level and reduce raised voices among adults in your household, because a consistently calm environment provides invisible education that a tense, chaotic home cannot.

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- **Observe whether your home feels orderly and predictable rather than reactive and chaotic, because the physical and emotional environment trains your child's nervous system just as surely as any lesson.:** Observe whether your home feels orderly and predictable rather than reactive and chaotic, because the physical and emotional environment trains your child's nervous system just as surely as any lesson.

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- **Audit the conflicts happening in your household and commit to modeling calm responses, because children learn self-regulation partly by watching how the adults around them handle frustration.:** Audit the conflicts happening in your household and commit to modeling calm responses, because children learn self-regulation partly by watching how the adults around them handle frustration.

#### TRAIN THROUGH DAILY PRACTICE

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- **Choose one specific habit to train this week using repetition and consistency, such as putting shoes away without being asked, because habits are how the will-muscle gets built.:** Choose one specific habit to train this week using repetition and consistency, such as putting shoes away without being asked, because habits are how the will-muscle gets built.

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  - **Replace commands with ideas by asking questions like 'How do you think Maya felt?' instead of saying 'You must share,' because ideas engage your child's thinking while commands trigger resistance.:** Replace commands with ideas by asking questions like 'How do you think Maya felt?' instead of saying 'You must share,' because ideas engage your child's thinking while commands trigger resistance.

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  - **Present situations as ideas that treat your child as a person capable of reasoning, because children become capable of reasoning when we respond to them as persons rather than just incentives and punishments.:** Present situations as ideas that treat your child as a person capable of reasoning, because children become capable of reasoning when we respond to them as persons rather than just incentives and punishments.
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- ☐ **Remain consistent with habit training over weeks and months rather than enforcing compliance through punishment, because the child who has truly internalized a habit has built lifelong self-management capacity.:** Remain consistent with habit training over weeks and months rather than enforcing compliance through punishment, because the child who has truly internalized a habit has built lifelong self-management capacity.

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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.